a moment in history too significant to pass by, and the thought of not participating haunted me.

Boots on the Ground

As I was thinking all this, I unexpectedly received a call from P.C. Vishnunadh, an INC leader and an MLA, with an invitation to walk alongside Rahul Gandhi and engage in a dialogue with him. My excitement was palpable because I had been waiting for this moment.

The Yatra set off from Kanyakumari, the southernmost tip of India, on 7 September 2022. A journalist posed a pertinent question: Why did Rahul choose to walk from the south to the north? Typically, political yatras originate in the north. Her observation was thought-provoking, suggesting that Rahul believed India had much to learn from the south, particularly when it came to the core principles of the Bharat Jodo Yatra. It was an optimistic belief that he could convey the message of national unity, diversity, tolerance and love from the south to the heartland of our incredible nation.

The Yatra crossed into Kerala on 11 September, where it received a grand welcome, with senior INC leaders in attendance. Many of them joined the walk for a significant portion of Rahul's twenty-day journey through Kerala. V.D. Satheesan, the incumbent Leader of the Opposition, noted that 'none of us has ever done this in our whole political career. We do jathas and yatras, but walking for so long was a challenge.' Their legs ached and their feet were worn, but the experience energized them with each passing day. Rahul displayed exceptional care, personally tending to ailing leaders such as Oommen Chandy, and ensuring their well-being.

Even in the bustling crowds, he maintained an intimate connection with the people. His eyes caught little children tripping in the crowd, mothers pushing and stumbling, girls who cried uncontrollably and out-of-breath elders. All of them were taken care of, many a time directly by him. He